request first we will try to pin down, concretise this general past request into some specific situation and request through the United Nations office, that is where he [Najibullah] is, at the moment', said Faleiro.[21] Rao added that despite being in 'almost hourly touch' with the situation in Afghanistan he 'would not venture to make any statement'.[22] In the light of changed circumstances, India had calculated that giving asylum to Najibullah might turn out to be prohibitively costly in political terms. If Najibullah would have escaped successfully, then India could have offered it as a fait accompli to the Mujahideen. Not anymore.

India refused to undertake a follow-up covert operation, by air or otherwise, to exfiltrate Najibullah from Kabul. With the Mujahideen having formed an internationally recognised though practically dysfunctional government, undertaking such an operation would amount to undermining Afghan sovereignty. Boutros-Ghali was informed that India was prepared to send a plane to Kabul only if the UN officially asked for it, and only after the UN reached a political agreement with Pakistan and the Mujahideen on the issue. But, as was being encouraged by the UN, India would not 'spirit out' Najibullah surreptitiously.[23] 'We had discussions of various possibilities with Najib [who] himself knew that he couldn't push India to take any kind of quasi-military action like this. It was not possible unless it was already discussed and negotiated [with the Mujahideen and Pakistan]', says Nambiar.[24] And at that time, India knew that negotiations with the Mujahideen would not work out, especially after the failed escape attempt. Either way, with a conservative Rao as PM of a minority government, and India's ongoing economic woes, such a covert operation was not a feasible option. As Nambiar put it, 'we didn't want to do something flamboyant and then get caught with our pants down'.[25] After years of partisanship towards the Mujahideen, in the wake of Najibullah's unceremonious ouster, the logic of conciliation began resonating in India's corridors of power.

Apart from keeping its promise of supporting Najibullah's family in Delhi, India did nothing more. Adjusting to the harsh realities of the end of the Cold War era, what Rao, Dixit, and Faleiro hoped for instead was the evolution of a definable political structure in Kabul, i.e. the Mujahideen government, with which India could make contact and move forward in its bilateral relationship.[26] The ignominious end to the Najibullah affair underlined the limits of influence